bare. Boys and girls go naked till seven years, and do not hide their shame.' In Calicut, he writes, 'there is a Muslim population resident, with two congregational mosques, and on Fridays they pray with peace of mind'. Nikitin also adds a detail that is at variance with Battuta's. He writes, 'It is the custom for foreign traders to stop at inns; there the food is cooked for the guests by the landlady, who also makes the bed and sleeps with the stranger. Women that know you willingly concede their favours, for they like white men.'

It later emerged that the only translation of Nikitin's account into English by Count Wielhorski had left untranslated certain salacious details from Nikitin, which add more context to the above remark: 'In India women are obtained by contract and they are cheap; you can have intercourse for two sitel. For four *fun* [a currency unit?] you can get a pretty one; for five [*fun*] —a pretty negress, all black with small and pretty nipples.'[8] Wielhorski also censored Nikitin's mention of his conversion to Islam. Whether Nikitin was seen as a Muslim in India is unclear but he too confirms the Hindu horror of 'impure' Muslims: 'They take care that Mahommedans do not look into their [cooking] pot, nor see their food, and should this happen they will not eat it; some, therefore, hide themselves under a linen cloth lest they should be seen when eating.'[9]

Making Sense of Marco Polo

What kind of a man was Marco Polo? Raised in the cosmopolitan and mercantile city state of Venice, Marco embraced something of its spirit and brought a merchant's pragmatic eye to bear on the world. His father and uncle—both enterprising merchants of Venice who accompanied him on his famous journey but left no records of their own—were early role models. When Marco began this journey, he was only seventeen. He returned in his late thirties and a few years later, in 1298 CE, teamed up with a romance writer, Rustichello of Pisa, to tell his story—a vast panorama of countries largely unknown to his fellow Venetians. As his translator, Ronald Latham, says:

> Persians, Turks, Tartars, Chinese, Tibetans, Indians, and a score of others defile before us, not indeed revealed in their inner thoughts and feelings, but faithfully portrayed in all